

Mattau Health

Community member

Health information for every village in Papua New Guinea.

More topics

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- Clean Water and Hygiene

This site gives general health information. If you or someone in your family is sick, go to your nearest health centre or talk to your village health worker.

Safe Motherhood

A healthy pregnancy and a safe birth protect both mother and baby. Start antenatal care early, plan for the birth, and know the danger signs.

For community members

Key messages

- As soon as you think you may be pregnant, go to the health centre. Signs are a missed period, bigger breasts, feeling sick in the morning, passing urine often, and a growing belly.
- Go for at least four antenatal care (ANC) visits. Each visit checks you and your baby, and gives you iron and folic acid tablets, tetanus injections, malaria medicine and a bed net.
- Ask to be tested for HIV and syphilis at your first visit. Testing early protects your baby.

- Make a birth plan with your family: where you will give birth, how you will get there, who will go with you, and what to take. Save money for transport. Keep your Helt Buk Bilong Ol Meri safe. It shows your due date, about 40 weeks after your last period.
- Plan to give birth at the health facility with a trained health worker.
- Eat a variety of foods, drink clean water, wash your hands, rest, and sleep under a treated mosquito net every night.
- After the birth, you and your baby need check-ups at the health centre on day 1, 3, 7 and 14, and at 6 weeks.
- Breastfeed your baby as soon as possible after birth, within the first 90 minutes. Give only breast milk for the first six months.

Go to the health centre straight away if you have

- Any bleeding from the vagina
- A very bad headache, blurred vision or fits
- Fever, or feeling very hot (it could be malaria)
- The baby moving much less, or not at all
- Severe pain in the belly, or burning pain when you pass urine
- Strong pains that come and go, before your due date
- Vomiting that will not stop late in pregnancy
- After the birth: heavy bleeding, fever, smelly fluid from the vagina, or belly pain

General information only. Follow the advice of your health centre and current national guidelines. Based on the National Department of Health Village Health Assistant (VHA) training curriculum.

TB

TB is an illness of the lungs. It spreads through the air when a person with TB coughs. TB can be cured if you take all your medicine.

For community members

Key messages

- A cough that lasts two weeks or more is a reason to be tested.
- Go to the health centre for a test. Do not wait.
- Take your medicine every day until the health worker says you are finished. This usually takes about six months. If you stop early, the TB can come back and be harder to treat.
- Cover your mouth when you cough and keep rooms airy.
- People who live with someone with TB should be checked too, especially children.

- TB can be a danger for pregnant women and their babies. Pregnant women are tested at antenatal care.

Get tested if you have

- A cough for two weeks or more
- Coughing up blood
- Chest pain
- Fever or night sweats
- Losing weight without trying
- Feeling very tired

General information only. Follow the advice of your health centre and current national guidelines.

AIDS

HIV is a virus that weakens the body's defences. It cannot be cured, but treatment lets people with HIV stay healthy for many years. Testing and treatment are free.

For community members

Key messages

- HIV spreads through sex without a condom, through blood (shared needles or razors), and from a mother to her baby in pregnancy, birth or breastfeeding.
- HIV does not spread by hugging, sharing food or plates, using the same toilet, or mosquito bites.
- You can get tested at the health centre. Knowing your status helps you protect yourself and your family.
- HIV medicine (ART) is life-long and free at ART sites. Taking it every day keeps the virus low.

- All pregnant women should be tested for HIV and syphilis at antenatal care. A mother who takes her medicine, gives birth at the facility, and gives only breast milk for six months can protect her baby. The baby gets medicine after birth and is tested at 6 weeks.
- Condoms protect against HIV and pregnancy. Do not share needles or razors. Tell your partner to get tested too.
- Do not shame or shut out people with HIV. Support them to stay on treatment. Keep their information private.

Think about getting tested if

- You had sex without a condom or with more than one partner
- You have TB
- You are pregnant
- Your partner has HIV
- You have had a long fever, diarrhoea or weight loss with no clear reason

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the National Department of Health Village Health Assistant (VHA) training curriculum.

Healthy Village

A healthy village is one where people plan together, keep water clean, and look after each other. Use the checklist below with your village leaders.

For community members

Key messages

- Hold regular village meetings about health, and agree on actions together.
- Protect your water source. Keep it clean and covered, and keep animals away.
- Build and use toilets, and dispose of rubbish safely.
- Support your village health worker, and take sick people to the health centre early.
- Look after old people, sick people and people with disabilities.
- Go through the Helti Ples checklist together. Choose one item to improve this month.

Helti Ples checklist

Tick one box for each: none, some or enough.

	None	Some	Enough
1. Village health committee			
2. Clean houses and good air			
3. Clean water			
4. Clean village everywhere			
5. Good health services			
6. A place of worship			
7. A good school			
8. Working together			
9. Small gardens near houses			
10. Good roads and transport			
11. Many ways to earn money			
12. Peace and good living together			
13. Community bank			

	None	Some	Enough
14. MCH clinic			
15. Change bad traditional customs			
16. Teach people about health			

Tell your village health worker or leader if

- Many people become sick at the same time
- The village water source is dirty or has dried up
- A mother or child needs help to reach the health centre

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Malaria

Malaria spreads through mosquito bites. It is dangerous, especially for babies, young children and pregnant women. Malaria can be cured, and the medicine is free at health facilities.

For community members

Key messages

- Sleep under a treated mosquito net every night. Nets should be replaced about every three years. Check yours for holes.
- If you have a fever, get tested within 24 hours at the health facility. A rapid test or a blood test shows if it is malaria. Do not just guess.
- Do not take malaria medicine only because you have a fever. Take it when a test shows malaria.
- If the test shows malaria, take the medicine for the full three days, even if you feel better after the first day. If you

are not better after three days, go back.

- Pregnant women should take the malaria prevention tablets (Fansidar) they are given at antenatal care.
- Clear bush and empty puddles around your house, where mosquitoes breed. Use repellent at night if you can afford it.

Go to the hospital or health centre now if there is

- Fits or confusion
- Being very sleepy or hard to wake
- Vomiting again and again, or not able to drink
- Fast or difficult breathing
- Very pale skin or yellow eyes
- Fever in a pregnant woman or a baby

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Farming

Good food from your own garden helps children grow strong and helps everyone fight sickness. Eat foods from many food groups every day.

For community members

Key messages

- Eat foods from as many of the eight food groups as you can every day.
- Plant a garden with green leafy vegetables like aibika and fern greens, orange and yellow vegetables and fruits like pumpkin, carrot and pawpaw, beans and peanuts, and a staple like kaukau, taro or cassava. Keep chickens or other animals for eggs and meat if you can.
- The first 1,000 days, from pregnancy to a child's second birthday, are the most important for growth and learning.
- Children aged 6 to 23 months should eat at least five of the eight groups every day.

- Pregnant and breastfeeding women should eat a variety of foods and avoid smoking and alcohol.
- Wash your hands before preparing food, and cover drinking water.
- Sell extra produce for school fees, medicine and transport.

Take your child to the health centre if they

- Are very thin, or have swollen feet
- Are not growing or gaining weight
- Have no energy and do not want to eat
- Have diarrhoea that does not stop

The eight food groups

- Breast milk (to 2 years or more)
- Grains, roots and tubers: rice, kaukau, taro, cassava, sago
- Beans, peas, nuts and seeds: peanuts, beans
- Dairy products

- Flesh foods: meat, fish, chicken
- Eggs
- Vitamin A rich fruits and vegetables: pumpkin, carrot, pawpaw, ripe mango, dark green leaves
- Other fruits and vegetables

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Child Health

Good care in the first two years builds a strong, healthy child. Feed well, vaccinate on time, keep your child clean, and act early when they are sick.

For community members

Key messages

- Breastfeed as soon as possible after birth. For the first six months give only breast milk. No water, juice, herbs, cow or goat milk, or other food.
- From six months, add soft foods from many food groups: mashed egg, fish, meat, beans, orange fruits like pawpaw, and dark green leaves. Keep breastfeeding to two years or more. Avoid sugary drinks and sweet biscuits.
- Never feed a baby with a bottle. It is hard to keep clean and can cause diarrhoea. Use a clean cup and spoon.

- Take your child for all vaccines on time. They are safe, effective and free. Check the Child Health Record Book. From 6 months your child needs vitamin A every six months, and from 12 months deworming tablets.
- Take your child every month to be weighed and measured. A MUAC tape around the arm shows if a child is too thin.
- Wash your hands with soap, boil drinking water, keep babies away from smoke and sick people, and sleep under a mosquito net.
- Keep breastfeeding when your child is sick. Give extra fluids.
- Give love and attention: smile, talk, play and praise. Raise children with words and guidance, not violence.

Take your child to the health centre within 24 hours if they have

- Fast breathing, chest pulling in, or a cough for 14 days or more
- Diarrhoea with blood, diarrhoea for 14 days or more, or signs of drying out: very thirsty, dry lips, passing very little urine
- Fever for 7 days or more, or fever with fits
- Not able to drink or breastfeed, or vomiting everything
- Very sleepy, hard to wake, or fits
- Swollen feet, or very thin arms

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Family Planning

Family planning means you decide when to have children, how many, and how far apart. It is your choice, and the methods are free at government health facilities.

For community members

Key messages

- A woman can become pregnant when she has sex with a man on her fertile days. A pregnancy lasts about 40 weeks.
- Spacing pregnancies protects the health of mothers and babies.
- There are many methods: condoms, an implant (replaced every 3 to 5 years), an injection every 3 months, an IUD (3 to 10 years), pills, and permanent methods for women or men.
- Condoms are the only method that also protects against sexually transmitted infections, including HIV.

- If a condom breaks or you had sex without protection, the emergency pill works up to 5 days afterwards.
- Side effects are different for every woman. Talk to a health worker to choose what suits you.
- All family planning methods are free at government and government-supported health facilities. If you are asked to pay, tell your ward health committee or the health centre manager.

See a health worker if

- You have a side effect or problem that worries you
- You had sex without protection and do not want to be pregnant
- You think you may have a sexually transmitted infection

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Clean Water and Hygiene

Clean hands, safe water and a clean village stop many sicknesses, especially diarrhoea in children.

For community members

Key messages

- Wash your hands with soap and water after using the toilet or cleaning a child, before cooking, before feeding children, before eating, and before breastfeeding.
- Water that looks clear is not always safe. Boil drinking water, let it cool, and keep it covered.
- Use a toilet. If you have none, bury stools. Keep animals away from small children.
- Dig a deep pit for rubbish, or bury or burn it. Rubbish attracts flies that spread germs.

- Wash plates and cups, and keep them covered from flies. A tippy tap is an easy way to wash hands with running water.
- Never use a baby bottle. Use a clean cup and spoon.

Take a child to the health centre if they have

- Diarrhoea with blood
- Diarrhoea for 14 days or more
- Very thirsty, dry lips and mouth, or passing very little urine
- Not able to drink or breastfeed, or vomiting everything

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